

3

Esotericism in the Shadow of the Enlightenment

I. Sunburst of Theosophy

1. At the Dawn of Illuminism

Translated into German in 1706 (with a Paracelsian commentary), the *Corpus Hermeticum* (CH) also was the subject of scholarly presentations in late Germanic humanism (*Bibliotheca Graeca* of J. A. Fabricius, 1708–1727). However, it also had recently been the subject, along with the neo-Alexandrian current, Rosicrucianism, and theosophy, of a refutation by Daniel Ehregott Colberg, a Lutheran theologian. His voluminous work *Das platonisch-hermetisches [sic] Christenthum* (1690–1691), as hostile as it may have been, nevertheless represents the first “history” ever written of the modern esoteric currents (until the end of the seventeenth century). It was soon followed by a monumental work by Gottfried Arnold, a theosopher and sophiologist ([chapter 2](#), section II, 2), who devoted a copious historical work to them (and to a good number of “mystical” authors) (*Unpartheyische Kirchen- und Ketzerhistorie*, 1699–1700). A little later came long and very critical developments by Jacob Brucker, a Protestant historian of philosophy, on Kabbalah, Pythagoreanism, and theosophy, in his *Historia critica philosophiae* (vols. II and IV, 1743)—a compendium widely read throughout the time of the Enlightenment and even later.

In England, in the 1720s, Dionysius Andreas Freher wrote many commentaries on the works of Boehme (they would remain unpublished but would circulate in various milieux open to receiving them), and William Law (*The Way to Divine Knowledge*, 1752) contributed to the continuity of the theosophical current. In Switzerland, the famous “Berleburg Bible” (1726–1742) also made a contribution, by

introducing it into the pietist milieu. It was again at Berleburg that Hector de Saint-Georges de Marsais published his works (such as *Explication de la Genèse*, 1738), influenced—as much as this Bible is—by Boehme, Mme Guyon, and Pierre Poiret. *Le Mystère de la Croix* (1732), a work signed by Douzetemps, is an example of an interpenetration of mysticism, pietism, and theosophy.

On the edge of this tendency orientated toward a certain form of “mysticism” another one appeared, by which the initiatic societies of the second half of the eighteenth century would draw inspiration, and which lies in a more Paracelsian wake. It is represented especially by three major works of a theosophical type, written in German and reprinted several times. These are, first, *Theo-Philosophia Theoretico practica* (1711) by Samuel Richter (*alias* Sincerus Renatus); second, *Aurea catena Homeri* (1723) by A. J. Kirchweger; and third, *Opus mago cabbalisticum et theosophicum* (1719) by Georg von Welling (*alias* Salwigt), a book that would long be deeply influential—not least on the young Johann Wolfgang Goethe.

Freemasonry as it is usually understood (i.e., “speculative Freemasonry”), appeared in London in 1717. Toward 1730, it introduced into its rituals the myth of the death and the resurrection of Hiram. This would favor the appearance—but essentially on the continent—starting from the 1750s, of masonic or paramasonic Rites (also sometimes called Systems, or Orders) with Higher Grades (or “Degrees”), that is, above the three grades of Entered Apprentice, Fellow Craft, and Master Mason, which constitute what is called “blue” or Craft Masonry. The creators of certain neo-Rosicrucian Higher Grades in the second half of the century drew upon the three works in German above (see also section III, 1, 2).

2. The Great Theosophers

The years from 1770 to about 1815 correspond to what it is commonly called the period of Illuminism (section I, 3). Theosophy then shone again in all its brilliance.

The Swede Emanuel Swedenborg (1688–1772), a reputed scientist, interrupted his properly scientific activities in 1745 following dreams that had suddenly come to transform his inner life. He immersed himself then in the study of the Bible and wrote his *Arcana coelestia* (1747–1758), followed by many other works.

Swedenborg presented his visions using images and figures that constitute a type of descriptive, even realistic, geography of the celestial spheres, of the “spiritual” worlds. His work greatly contributed to disseminate to a wide audience the idea of universal correspondences that, from Nature to humanity and from humanity to God, appear as an indefinite series of intermediaries. In the natural world, any object, even the most minor, “corresponds” to something that partakes of a higher order of reality, without solution of continuity. A sometimes colorful but generally rather flat style is off-putting to many readers,

but the fame of this visionary spread quickly as early as the 1770s, notably by means of many translations and abridgements. They penetrated into various intellectual milieux. Immanuel Kant devoted a whole treatise to Swedenborg (*Träume eines Geistersehers*, 1766; translated as *Dreams of a Spirit Seer*). Moreover, no theosopher has exerted a more significant influence on literature than he has. Most of the other great theosophers did not value Swedenborg highly, whose Christology appeared suspicious to them and whose cosmology left little room for Nature. However, “Swedenborgianism” inspired some masonic Rites and, in 1787, even incited Anglican ecclesiastics to create a little Church, the New Church, still flourishing today.

The Swabian Friedrich Christoph Oetinger (1702–1782; section II, 3), Lutheran pastor, Nature philosopher, and alchemist, nourished by Boehme and the Kabbalah, exegete of Swedenborg from whom he nevertheless strongly distanced himself, represents a form of eclectic and erudite esotericism. *Magia*, the highest of sciences, is for him a method of knowledge in the search for connections between terrestrial and celestial physics. Everything, for him, is “physical”—however “subtle” it may be. There are no such things as pure spirits (“Corporeality is the end [the goal] of the works of God,” was one of his mottos). To practice a “superior physics” and a permanent hermeneutic (nourished by Kabbalah and alchemy) can furnish us with keys to knowledge about the relationships between Nature and the Bible. Among his principal works appeared *Biblisches und emblematisches Wörterbuch* (1776), and *Oeffentliches Denckmal der Princessen Antonia* (1763; the latter consists of a commentary on the *Turris Antonia*, cf. [chapter 2](#), section III, 3). Through an essay on the Kabbalah of Isaac Luria ([chapter 2](#), section I, 2), Oetinger contributed to make known to the German pietists the Hassidism that is spiritually so close to pietism.

Less a physicist and less a Kabbalist, Michael Hahn (1758–1819) is, however, a great theosopher in the lineage of Boehme. His writings on androgyny and the Sophia remain classics of the genre. More celebrated, more popular by his writings, only little influenced by Boehme, is Karl von Eckartshausen (1752–1803; section III, 3), of Munich. His work (which includes *Zahlenlehre der Natur* [1794] and the famous *Die Wolke über dem Heiligthum*—1802, translated as *The Cloud upon the Sanctuary*) is exceedingly rich. His major books, translated and republished in several languages (many in Russian, notably), have to date never ceased to find a hearing. It is also in German that the Alsatian Frédéric R. Saltzmann wrote, in the first years of the nineteenth century, a theosophical work in the Boehmean wake, but with a more limited reception (*Es wird alles neu werden*, 1802–1810).

The *Traité de la Réintégration des êtres*, by Martines de Pasqually (1727–1774; section III, 1)—the founder of the theurgical Order of the Élus-Coëns—is one of the masterpieces of modern theosophy. Under its influence, Louis-Claude de Saint-Martin (1743–1803; [chapter 4](#), section I, 2), who would call

himself “the Unknown Philosopher,” composed his first two works, *Des Erreurs et de la vérité* (1775) and *Tableau naturel des rapports qui existent entre Dieu, l'homme et l'univers* (1781). During a sojourn in Strasbourg (1788–1791), he befriended Frédéric R. Saltzmann (cf. *supra*) who had him discover Boehme. Henceforth strongly under Boehme's spell, he produced other master works of theosophy, including *L'Homme de désir* (1790), *Le Nouvel homme* and *Ecce Homo* (1792), *Le Ministère de l'Homme-Esprit* and *De l'Esprit des choses* (1802).

Saint-Martin was not simply an emulator of Pasqually and of Boehme, but was especially the most important theosopher of his time as well as one of the principal representatives of preromantic literature in France. His influence, as much direct as diffuse, has never ceased to make itself felt. He has left behind interesting correspondence with masons or Élus-Coëns such as Jean-Baptiste Willermoz (1730–1824; section II, 3; section III, 1), as well as with personalities spiritually still closer to him, such as the Bernese Niklaus Anton Kirchberger (1739–1799).

In this gallery of famous theosophers, another Swiss has his place, Jean-Philippe Dutoit-Membrini (1721–1793), author of a *Philosophie divine* (1793) that also appears among the important works produced by this current. Finally, the last years of the century and the period of the Empire saw the emergence, especially in Germany, of a Nature philosophy (a *Naturphilosophie*) often strongly tinged with theosophy (*infra*, section III).

3. Faces of Illuminism

As recalled earlier, *Illuminism* is the term used to refer to a general orientation of thought that flourished from the 1760s to the beginning of the nineteenth century. If it is especially represented by the theosophers, it is also by all those who found themselves more or less in affinity with them, and by a number of initiatic societies (*infra*, section III). Accordingly, won over generally to theosophy but marked by forms of devotional esotericism or notable singularities as well, various characters compose this gallery.

First is the engaging Johann Caspar Lavater (1741–1801). A Lutheran minister in Zurich, curious about supernatural phenomena, he did not scorn theurgy, practiced animal magnetism occasionally, and developed ideas impregnated with a form of naturalistic Christology (*Aussichten in die Ewigkeit*, 1768–1778), but posterity sees in him especially the first great modern theoretician of physiognomy (*Physiognomische Fragmente*, 1775–1778). Probably few German-speaking thinkers since Luther maintained a correspondence as monumental as his.

Johann Heinrich Jung-Stilling (1740–1817; section III, 3) resembled him by the magnitude of his correspondence and his researches in “metapsychical” phenomena (*Theorieder Geisterkunde*, 1807).

Communications with the spirit world were also a focal point for Jean Frederic Oberlin (1740–1826), a Protestant minister in Steinthal (Alsace). In Russia, Ivan Vladimirovich Lopukhin (1775–1815; section III, 1) has left a short work that met with long-standing success: *Quelques traits de l'Église intérieure* (Some Characteristics of the Interior Church), written in Russian in 1791, published in French in 1798, several times translated and republished, close to Hesychasm by the techniques of prayer that are taught in it. This prominent figure of Russian Freemasonry translated into his language, and published, texts by Boehme, Swedenborg, Eckartshausen, and Jung-Stilling.

Besides these avenues of Christian spirituality, Illuminism included other figures, of a neo-pagan orientation. If Antoine Fabre d'Olivet wrote *La Langue hébraïque restituée* (1810, published in 1816–1817; section II, 4), it was not by Christian zeal but rather by a concern to discover the origin of language. His *Vers dorés de Pythagore* (1813) attempt to demonstrate the existence of a lost but universal Tradition. Less philosophical, and mainly encyclopedic, is the great survey realized by Antoine Court de Gébelin, *Le Monde primitif* (1773–1784), one of the first attempts to find, through the exploration of various known traditions, something that resembles what would later be called the “primordial Tradition” ([chapter 5](#), section II, 1, 2). Moreover, the egyptophilian trend of that time inspired many discourses and practices replete with initiatic frameworks—from the novel by Abbot Terrasson (*Sethos*, 1731) to *Nouvelles recherches sur l'origine et la destination des pyramides d'Égypte* (1812) by A. P. J. de Vismes, including “Egyptian Masonries” (section III, 2) like *The Magic Flute* (Mozart's opera, 1791) and *Kostis Reise* (1795, a short novel by Eckartshausen).

II. From the Art of Reading to the Art of Subtle Fluids

1. Continuity of the Occult Sciences

Thanks to some learned treatises, interest in Christian Kabbalah had not yet entirely abated in the second half of the century. Thus, initiated by the Christian Cabbalist Christian Fende and by the Jewish Kabbalist Koppel Hecht, Oetinger (section I, 2) wrote his famous *Lehrtafel* (“Didactic tablet,” 1763), an interpretation of an altarpiece painted in the preceding century and conserved in the church of Bad Teinach ([chapter 2](#), section III, 3). Pythagoreanism and Hermetism pursued their virtually uninterrupted course (to wit, many neo-Pythagorean writings, such as *Les Voyages de Pythagore en Égypte*, by Sylvain Maréchal, 1799; and a new German translation of the *Pimander*, 1781).

In the less learned context of the salons and the street corners, the era of Illuminism was hospitable to the career of characters expert in exploiting the taste for the marvelous, such as the Count of Saint Germain (?–1784) and Joseph Balsamo (*alias* Cagliostro (1743 [?]-1795; section II, 2). The powers that

credulous contemporaries attributed to them reflect a general taste for the so-called occult sciences, as witnessed notably by the editions of books of popular magic (like the *Grand Albert* and the *Petit Albert*), by heated debates on vampirism (especially from 1732 to the *Traité sur les apparitions* [1746] of Dom Calmet), and witchcraft. Noteworthy too is the widespread interest evinced at that time for automata and entertaining experiments in physics.

An engaging and disconcerting character incarnates rather well the different forms of this state of mind on the eve of the Revolution. This was the Frenchman Jean-Baptiste Alliette (*alias* Etteilla), a combination of charlatan and theosopher, and an alchemist as well (*Les Sept Nuances de l'oeuvre philosophique*, 1786). One of his claims to glory is to have been practically the first to spread the idea that the Tarot cards, so-called of Marseille, would go back to ancient Egypt and would contain sublime mysteries. A little later, more in the wake of Agrippa's *De Occulta philosophia* ([chapter 2](#), section I, 1; [chapter 2](#), section III, 1), a compilation destined for great success prefigures the editorial production of the occultist current that would flourish starting in the middle of the nineteenth century. This is *The Magus* (1801), by Francis Barrett (besides whom we may also cite Karl Joseph Windischmann, author of *Untersuchungen über Astrologie, Alchemie und Magie*, 1813).

Music was the subject of esoteric speculations, not least with regard to synesthesia: an ocular (color-liquid) clavichord or “color piano” (it displayed colors supposed to be in harmony with the notes) was described notably by the Jesuit Louis-Bertrand Castel around 1740—and later more extensively by Eckartshausen (section I, 2; section III, 3) in his *Aufschlüsse zur Magie* (1788). But Saint-Martin (section I, 2) was perhaps the only one of the century to integrate perfectly an elaborate speculation about music into a theosophical discourse (especially in *Des Erreurs et de la Vérité*, 1775, and *De l'Esprit des choses*, 1802). However, A. P. J. de Vismes also appeared on this terrain (*Essai sur l'homme, ou l'homme microcosme*, 1805) and Fabre d'Olivet, with his first researches (section I, 3). Finally, it was a period of intense activity for illuminated prophets: Suzette Labrousse and Catherine Théot in revolutionary France; on the eve of the Empire, Mademoiselle Lenormand; in England, Richard Brothers; in Germany, Thomas Poeschl—and many others a bit everywhere.

2. Alchemy, Shadow Side of the Enlightenment and Light of Mythology

The progress of chemistry, which definitively acquired its status of a scientific discipline, already heralded the irremediable decline of operative alchemy. However, interest remained lively and the literature abundant, even after the publication of the works of Lavoisier. In the *Encyclopedia* of Diderot, the articles “Alchemy” and “Alchemist” by Maloin were not testimony to hostility toward this “science.” This is because scholars believed to read in it a poorly explored area of investigation. The common

people saw in it a source of immediate wealth, the unconditional rationalists a practice of charlatans, and for part of the public it was an aspect among others of the marvelous. This concerned especially the manufacturing of material gold (the alchemy called “operative”), but, as in the preceding periods, it is not always easy to distinguish “operative” and “spiritual” alchemy—the latter, as we have seen, often being considered as a form of sublime knowledge. From a still considerable editorial production (but from which the tradition of fine illustrations had unfortunately disappeared), let us highlight three aspects of which the first two were situated in the extension of what we have mentioned *supra* ([chapter 2](#), section III, 2), but took renewed forms.

The first aspect is illustrated by the vogue that the compilations of treatises continued to enjoy. Whereas the anthology of Jean-Jacques Manget ([chapter 3](#), section III, 2) was in Latin, there now appeared, in the vernacular, the *Deutsches Theatrum Chemicum* (1728) of Friedrich Roth-Scholtz, the *Neue Alchymistische Bibliothek* (1772) of F. J. W. Schröder, and others like them. As a corollary, there was a public demand for historiographical presentations: hence the publication of works such as the *Bibliotheca chemica* (1727) of Roth-Scholtz, the *Histoire de la philosophie hermétique* (1742) of Nicolas Lenglet-Dufresnoy, and the *Dictionnaire mytho-hermétique* (1758) of the Benedictine Antoine Joseph Pernety (section III, 2).

The second aspect is characterized (as previously, [chapter 2](#), section III, 2) by the tendency to give stories of Greek and Egyptian mythology an alchemical reading. This was achieved by reducing the antique “Fables” to an allegorical discourse, whose sole purpose would have been the encrypted description of procedures of transmutation (typical in this regard are the *Fables égyptiennes et grecques dévoilées*, 1758, by Antoine Dom Pernety). Alternatively, it was accomplished by interpreting this mythology on several levels, in a nonreductionist manner, following a hermeneutic of a theosophical type (thus proceeded Hermann Fictuld, *Aureum Vellus*, 1749; Ehrd de Naxagoras, *Aureum Vellus*, 1753, both in German; or again Anselmo Caetano, *Ennoea*, 1732–1733, in Portuguese).

The third aspect of alchemy at the time of the Enlightenment was its diffuse but obvious presence among scientists and Nature philosophers more or less won over to Paracelsism such as Johann Juncker (*Conspectus chemiae theoretico-practicae*, 1730) and, later of course, Oetinger. This characteristic prefigured Romantic *Naturphilosophie* (section IV, 1, 2).

3. Animal Magnetism

According to one of the most widespread ideas in alchemical thought, matter contains a light or an invisible fire whose nature is that of the Word who created Light on the first Day. This igneous principle, halfway between the natural and the supersensible, also occupies an important place in many

cosmological discourses of the West. It has served to interpret the Platonic idea of the World Soul and has diversified into countless themes and motifs. Spread in the eighteenth century, the tendency to mix experimental research and speculative thought favored the reappearance of this principle under new forms. In the seventeenth century, Rudolf Göckel and Athanasius Kircher ([chapter 2](#), section I, 1) were passionately interested in phenomena of a magnetic and electric nature.

At the time of the Enlightenment, some Nature philosophers close to Oetinger (section I, 2) developed a “theology of electricity.” These were especially J. L. Fricker, G. F. Rösler, Prokop Divisch (*Theorie der meterologischen Elektrizität*, 1765). Their speculations were clad in a light of religiosity, but those of the Swabian doctor Franz Anton Mesmer (1734–1815) were not—he was a materialist. Mesmerism, however, soon became a source of inspiration to most of the representatives of the esoteric currents of that time.

As early as 1766, in his doctoral thesis, *De influx planetarum in corpus humanum*, Mesmer had postulated the existence of an invisible fluid spread everywhere. It would serve as a vehicle for the mutual influence that the celestial bodies would exert between themselves, the Earth and animate bodies—whence the expression “animal magnetism” generally employed to refer to this theory and the practices connected with it. Having first cared for his patients by the application of magnets (a procedure later readopted by Jean-Martin Charcot), then by the laying on of hands, he developed a therapy that consisted in having people sit next to one another around a tub—the famous *baquet*—containing water, iron filings, and sand. They communicated with the tub by means of iron rods or ropes and thus formed a “chain” in order to transmit into the bodies of the sick patients the “magnetism” of the healthy subjects. Established in Paris in 1778, Mesmer enjoyed great success there but also came up against the incomprehension of official medicine. Nicolas Bergasse attempted to develop a doctrine of magnetism (*Théorie du monde et des êtres organisés*, 1784) that was to prove influential for many decades.

Although a convinced materialist, Mesmer himself gave his activities an “initiatric” character by creating in 1783 a Society of Harmony of which a number of symbols were inspired by the masonic style. And, in 1785, he wrote that “we are endowed with an internal sense that is in relationship with the whole of the entire universe”—an idea that would not fail to create many repercussions in the currents we are dealing with. This was all the more so as the notion of “internal sense,” widespread in that period, assumed different meanings there. Whereas according to Kant this notion resembles an impoverishment, in the case of Mesmer it can signify on the contrary a deployment of the possibilities of our being. Anyhow, far from spreading in the specific form that Mesmer had attempted to confer on it, animal magnetism could soon be seen operating in several directions.

Notably, whereas Mesmer had conceived the practice for an essentially therapeutic purpose, as early as 1784, in France, the Marquis Armand Marie Jacques de Chastenet de Puységur (1727–1807), who “magnetized” his subjects by sending them into a state of consciousness close to sleep, believed he had discovered the possibility of nonverbal control exercised on them by the magnetizer. He was one of the first to consider the material supports used by Mesmer (such as magnets, tubs, etc.) as nonessential. He was also among the first, in the history of animal magnetism, to attempt to show that a magnetized person can sometimes be capable of “clairvoyance,” that is, seeing objects that are hidden or situated in distant places, predicting things in the future, diagnosing illnesses and indicating their remedies, and so on. Thus, open to the “paranormal,” animal magnetism could even be considered by many as a means to establish contacts with the beyond; for example, by Jean-Baptiste Willermoz, in Lyons, and by some of the principal representatives of *Naturphilosophie* in Germany ([chapter 4](#), section I, 3). Let us also recall that animal magnetism was not merely a fashion or an isolated episode, but represented a most important cultural trend at the twilight of the Enlightenment, in romantic thought in the broad sense, and in the history of dynamic psychiatry until the time of Sigmund Freud inclusively.

III. A Century of Initiations

1. Strict Observance and Rectified Scottish Rite

Much more than the first three Grades (Entered Apprentice, Fellow Craft, Master Mason) of Freemasonry, it was, we have seen ([chapter 3](#), section I, 1), the Higher Grades of certain Rites that drew from the thematic corpus of the esoteric currents. Before reviewing the principle ones of these Rites, let us first introduce two of the most famous. The first, called Strict Observance (SO), created by the Baron Karl von Hund toward 1750, presented itself as a direct descendant (so at least it claimed to be) of the Order of the Temple destroyed by Philip IV the Fair. SO remained the most important masonic Rite in Germany for about thirty years. The second was the Rectified Scottish Rite (RER), which included the so-called Order of the Knights Beneficient of the Holy City (Chevaliers Bienfasants de la Cité Sainte [CBCS])—from the name of the sixth grade of the RER. This Rite, whose principal architect was the theosopher from Lyons Jean-Baptiste Willermoz (section I, 2; section III, 1), was not of a theurgic character although it was inspired from the Order of the Élus-Coëns founded in France some time around 1754 by the theosopher Martines de Pasqually ([chapter 3](#), section I, 2).

At the end of the 1770s, two of the principal personalities of the SO, Duke Ferdinand von Brunswick and Prince Karl von Hessen-Cassel, decided to assemble the representatives of European Freemasonry in a great Masonic Convention responsible for reflecting on the origin, the nature, the reason for being of

this institution. With this in mind, Ferdinand sent out circulars to various personalities (Joseph de Maistre, initiated into the RER, responded with his famous *Mémoire* of 1780). The Convention met at Wilhelmsbad in July–August 1782. There, the myth of Templar filiation was discarded, and the orientation represented by the RER became an object of global acceptance.

This Convention was an important event of the era because we can see two categories of Masons confronted there. Some were attracted to various forms of “esotericism”; others instead staunchly adhered to the philosophy of the Enlightenment. Under the name “Martinism” (from the names of Saint-Martin and de Pasqually), the RER quickly gained footing in Russia where the Golden Rosy-Cross (*infra*, 2) had also penetrated and where the masons Lopukhin (section I, 3) and Nicolay Ivanovich Novikov stood out as two of the principle representatives of this orientation.

2. Other Masonic and Paramasonic Systems

Let us distinguish between, on the one hand, the Christian Rites (of which SO and RER are part), of a medieval “chivalrous” type, having the Holy Land, Jerusalem, as their “Orient” of reference; and, on the other hand, the rather neo-pagan or “Egyptian” Rites. Between them, however, the frontier was fluid and, of course, the same person could appear simultaneously in several of these Rites. An Order that called itself “Rosicrucian,” constituted in the 1770s in Germany, achieved the cohesion of its Lodges or “Circles” in 1777 by naming itself the Gold- und Rosenkreutzer Älteren Systems (Golden Rosicrucians of the Ancient System), and by endowing itself with nine grades very marked by alchemical symbolism. With the advent (1786) of the new King of Prussia Frederick William II, who had taken initiation into that Order, the latter entered into definitive dormancy without having been for as much forbidden. Its editorial activities constituted a non-negligible aspect of production of an esoteric type at the end of the century (cf. e.g., the *Geheime Figuren der Rosenkreutzer*, 1785–1788, a collection of plates and texts that would often be reproduced and interpreted).

Pernety (section II, 2) may have known Golden Rosicrucians in Berlin where he found himself from 1767 to 1782 in the position of curator of the Royal Library of Frederick II. He left this city in 1783, went to Avignon, established not far from there his (non-masonic) society known as the Illuminés d'Avignon, and engaged in oracular practices of interrogating a “Sainte Parole” (“Holy Word”), a sort of hypostasis of the Supreme Intelligence. The Polish staroste Thaddeus Leszczyc Grabianka, a member of this Society, created a dissident group in this city, called The New Israel, whose head was Ottavio Cappelli, a gardener believed to be receiving communications from the archangel Raphael. The revolutionary upheaval scattered the Illuminés d'Avignon, of which many personalities of Europe were part.

Let us cite eleven other initiatic societies of a Christian character. The Swedish Rite was established toward 1750 by Karl Friedrich Eckleff. The Ordre de l'Étoile Flamboyante was founded by Théodore Henri de Tschoudy (1766). The Rite of Johann Wilhelm Zinnendorf (1770) was inspired by the Swedish Rite. The Klerikat (Clericate) was the creation of Johann August Starck toward 1767. The Society of the Philalethes came to birth in 1773; this Society, which was probably the first institute of research into Freemasonry, had Charles Pierre Savalette de Langes among its foremost members. In Paris, in 1785 and 1787, it organized two international interobediential Conventions meant to put all the possible documents and archives in common with a view to discovering or rediscovering the true principles on which Freemasonry should rest. The Brethren of the Cross was a Rite founded by Christian Heinrich Haugwitz toward 1777. The Asiatic Brethren, in Austria and in south Germany especially, was the creation of Hans Heinrich von Ecker- und Eckhoffen in 1781. François Marie Chefdebien d'Armissan and his father founded The Primitive Rite of the Philadelphians in 1780. The Illuminated Theosophists, of Swedenborgian type, important in England and in the United States was a Rite born toward 1783 under the impetus of Benedict Chastanier. The Ancient and Accepted Scottish Rite (REAA) came to birth in France around 1801. The Order of the Orient was founded in 1804 and organized in 1806 by Bernard-Raymond Fabré-Palaprat, under the denomination of the Johannite Church of Primitive Christians, which is a neo-Templar organization. With the three systems cited in the preceding section (SO, Elect-Cohens, and RER), we count here fourteen of them.

As for the “neo-pagan” Rites, of “Egyptian” character for the most part, they were principally the five following: the African Architects, creation of Friedrich von Köppen toward 1767; the Egyptian Rite created by Cagliostro (section II, 1), which dates from 1784; at the beginning of the French Empire appeared in Italy the Rite of Misraïm (although not very “Egyptian” in character), which was imported into France by the Bédarride brothers, and followed in 1815 by the Rite of Memphis—to which it is fitting to add that of the so-called Magi of Memphis, created at the end of the eighteenth century and that refers explicitly to Hermes Trismegistus. But this list of nineteen Rites does not claim to be exhaustive.

3. Initiation in Art

The eighteenth century saw a proliferation of works of fiction replete with mysteries. Witnesses to this were first a French translation of the *Arabian Nights* (“Les Mille et une Nuits”) by Antoine Galand (1704), of re-editions and translations of the *Comte de Gabalis* ([chapter 2](#), section III, 3), or again a collection of imposing dimensions such as the *Voyages imaginaires* (cf. notably volume XIV, *Relation du Monde de Mercure*). Then, fruitful relationships were sealed between eighteenth-century Illuminism and literature. In *Le Diabolo amoureux* (1772) of Jacques Cazotte (a well-known “Illuminé”), we can

detect one of the direct origins of the specific type of writing that would flourish starting in the mid-nineteenth century and that would be known as the classical ‘fantastic’ genre in literature of fiction. In the period of Illuminism, works of fiction were sometimes of a humorous (Mouhy, *Lamekis*, 1737) or parodic (F. H. von Hippel, *Kruez-und Querzüge*, 1793) bent, sometimes more serious—notably starting in the last ten years of the eighteenth century, especially in Germany; in which case it was illustrated by novelists such as Jean Paul (*Die Unsichtbare Loge*, 1793), Johann Heinrich Jung-Stilling (*Heimweh*, 1794; section I, 3), Eckartshausen (*Kostis Reise*, 1795; section I, 2), Saint-Martin (*Le Crocodile*, 1799), Novalis (*Heinrich von Ofterdingen* and *Die Lehrlinge zu Sais*, 1802), Ernst Theodor Amadeus Hoffmann (*Der golden Topf*, 1813), and even by Goethe (cf. the tale “Das Märchen,” 1795 [translated into English under the title *The Green Snake and the Beautiful Lily*]; his poem “Das Geheimnisse,” 1785; certain passages in *Faust Part One*).

The opera of Mozart *The Magic Flute* (1791) and the drama of Zacharias Werner *Die Söhne des Thals* (1802–1804) remain two of the most well known works in the performing arts. William Blake, poet, engraver, bard of the creative imagination (*The Marriage of Heaven and Earth*, 1793; *Visions of the Daughter of Albion*, 1793), transmuted contributions from many currents, among which Swedenborgism, in the alchemical furnace of his genius. We could cite many other authors in the English domain, such as James Thomson, of which *The Seasons* (1726–1730) revealed deep tinges of Hermetism. More than all the other painters of German romanticism, Philipp Otto Runge ([chapter 2](#), section I, 5) was close to theosophy, especially to that of Boehme (cf. his painting of “Morning,” 1808). Finally, in Italy, we owe Prince Raimondo di Sangro di San Severo, from whom Cagliostro received teachings, the astonishing “Hermetic monument” preserved in the San Severo Chapel in Naples.